Theotokia

A discussion and devotional card game about the Virgin Mary in Coptic Orthodox tradition — Ages 12+ — 3-8 Players — 25-35 Minutes

Age Range	Players	Play Time	Difficulty
12+	**3-8**	**25-35 min**	**Easy-Medium**

About This Game

Theotokia is a devotional card game that guides players into deeper understanding of the Virgin Mary — the Theotokos — in the Coptic Orthodox tradition. Through titles, feasts, Scripture, and hymns, players explore who she is, why the Church honours her, and what her life teaches us about faithfulness, humility, and the Incarnation.

> **Formation Goal:** To know and love St. Mary not as a distant historical figure but as the Mother of God who intercedes for us, a model of obedience, and a living witness to the mystery of the Incarnation.

Components

- **10 Title Cards** (white) — Names and titles given to the Theotokos by the Church Fathers and in liturgical tradition
- **10 Feast Cards** (light red) — Major feasts of St. Mary in the Coptic calendar
- **10 Scripture Cards** (light amber) — Key Bible passages about or connected to the Virgin Mary
- **10 Hymn Cards** (light purple) — Excerpts from the daily Theotokia and other Coptic hymns
- **1 Rules Sheet** (this page)
- **1 Leader Guide**
- **1 Reflection Sheet**

Setup

1. Separate the 40 cards into four face-down decks by type: Titles, Feasts, Scripture, and Hymns.
2. Shuffle each deck separately.
3. Place the four decks in the centre of the table where all players can reach them.
4. Choose a leader to guide the discussion (or rotate leadership each round).

How to Play

Round Structure

The game is played over **5 rounds**. Each round follows these steps:

1. **Draw:** The leader draws one card from each of the four decks (4 cards total) and places them face-up in the centre.
2. **Read Aloud:** The leader reads each card aloud, one at a time: the title/name, the description, and the reflection question at the bottom.
3. **Discuss by Type:**
   - **Title Cards:** What does this title reveal about Mary? How does it connect to the Old Testament?
   - **Feast Cards:** What happened on this day? What does the Church want us to remember?
   - **Scripture Cards:** Read the passage (from a Bible if available). What does this verse show us about Mary's character?
   - **Hymn Cards:** If anyone knows the hymn, sing a line together. What image does the hymn use to describe Mary?
4. **Choose:** After discussing all four cards, each player silently chooses the card that resonated with them most. Go around the table and share your choice and why.
5. **Collect:** Set aside the four cards. Begin the next round by drawing four new cards.

After 5 Rounds

Once all rounds are complete (20 cards discussed), the remaining 20 cards can be explored freely, used for a second session, or distributed for personal reflection.

Alternate Modes

Deep Dive (2-4 players, 40-50 min)

Draw only 2 cards per round instead of 4. Spend more time on each card. Play 10 rounds to cover 20 cards. Best for small groups or mentoring sessions.

Quick Round (5-8 players, 15-20 min)

Play only 3 rounds. After each round, the group votes on the most meaningful card. Set aside the winning cards and display them together at the end as a "portrait of St. Mary."

Tips for Leaders

- There are no wrong answers in discussion. Every genuine response is valuable.
- If the group is quiet, share your own reflection first to model vulnerability.
- Encourage players to connect the cards to their own experience: "Has this ever reminded you of something in your life?"
- Use the Leader Guide for deeper theological background on each card type.
- Close with the Reflection Sheet so players can record what moved them.
- This game works beautifully during the month of Kiahk, the fasts of St. Mary, or any youth gathering.
- If a player knows a hymn mentioned on a card, invite them to sing it. Music opens the heart in ways that words alone cannot.

> *"My soul magnifies the Lord, and my spirit has rejoiced in God my Saviour. For He who is mighty has done great things for me, and holy is His name." — Luke 1:46-49*